

Computer and Digital Forensics

CYFI 725

Instructor

Dr. Frank (Weifeng) Xu

E-mail: wxu@ubalt.edu

Office: LAP 526 **Phone:** 410-837-5302

Office hours: By appointment

Class Information

Credits: 3 credits

Lecture time: Mo 17:30–21:15

Location: BC 015 (in person); Zoom (online)

Zoom: [Join the online class](#)

<https://ubalt.zoom.us/j/5547149563>

This syllabus and related course instructions are available at https://github.com/frankwxu/public_space.

Course Description

This course examines fundamental principles and hands-on practices in computer and digital forensics. It examines the use of computer-forensic theories, techniques, and tools for the retrieval, recovery, authentication, and analysis of electronic data from file systems and memory, with extensive use of Windows and Linux command lines. Students reconstruct computer usage associated with cybercrimes.

Prerequisite: CYFI 620.

Meeting Format

The course meets every Monday and is offered in two formats:

- **Hybrid (HYB):** In-person attendance on campus is required on September 14, September 28, October 12, October 26, and November 9; all remaining lectures will be held remotely via Zoom.
- **Zoom (ZM):** Remote attendance via Zoom is required for all class sessions.

Student Learning Outcomes

- Illustrate an understanding of file-system internals, with a focus on Windows- and Linux-based systems.
- Apply digital-forensic techniques and tools to retrieve evidence from file systems and memory.
- Demonstrate hands-on abilities for reconstructing evidence from media storage devices.
- Identify network architectures and use essential network-forensic tools to retrieve files from network traffic.

Textbook and Learning Resources

- **Optional:** Xu, Weifeng, Lin Deng, and Mohit Dhabuwala. 2025. *Digital Forensics Basics: A Step-by-Step Guide for Beginners: An Open-Source Approach* (Second Edition). Kindle edition. August 1. Amazon. <https://www.amazon.com/dp/B0HH8WQSMK>.
- **Book:** [Digital Forensics Introduction PDF](#). **Access:** Available to enrolled students.

Course Topics (Tentative)

- Number System
- Introduction to Computer Systems
- Working with Windows and Command-Line Systems
- Linux and Macintosh File Systems
- Understanding the Digital Forensics Profession and Investigations
- Forensic Tools: Sleuth Kit Tutorial and Data Acquisition
- Evidence Search
- Data Carving
- Introduction to Network Forensics

- Memory Forensics

Grading Criteria

Lab/Projects/Homework/Quizzes: 200 points

Midterm: 100 points

Final: 100 points

Total: 400 points

Grade thresholds: A: 95%; A-: 90%; B+: 87%; B: 83%; B-: 80%; C+: 77%; C: 73%; C-: 70%; F: below 70%.

Potential Grade Adjustments for Active Engagement: Final grades near the next higher letter-grade threshold (e.g., 89% or 89.5% near the 90% threshold for an A-) may be considered for a **discretionary upgrade**. Adjustments are not guaranteed and depend on the instructor's assessment of your overall active engagement during Zoom sessions. Examples include keeping your camera on during group discussions, regularly contributing via audio, or consistently participating.

Grade policy

- **Submission requirements:** All labs, assignments, and quizzes must be submitted through Canvas unless otherwise instructed by the instructor.
- **Late submissions:** Late homework, quizzes, and labs will not be accepted for credit.
- **Attendance:** Missing two or more class sessions will result in a failing course grade.
- **Make-up assessments:** Make-up quizzes and exams require prior arrangements with the instructor.
- **Technical questions:** When emailing a technical question, include relevant screenshots, the commands you used, and the steps you took to verify your results.
- **Grade appeals:** Submit grade appeals by email within two weeks of receiving the grade. Appeals submitted after this deadline will not be considered.
- **Grade calculation:** Final course percentages are calculated by dividing points earned by total available points and multiplying by 100.

Appeal a Grade

When appealing a grade, it is important to provide a clear and well-justified reason for why the grade should be re-evaluated. Use the following template and include relevant supporting reasons.

[Your Name]
[Your Student ID]
[Course Name and Number]
[Date]

1. **Detailed Explanation of the Issue:** Clearly and concisely describe the specific aspect(s) of your work that you believe were not accurately assessed or graded. Be as specific as possible and refer to relevant sections of your assignment or exam.
2. **Providing Supporting Evidence:** Attach or reference relevant materials, such as rubrics, assignment guidelines, or notes from class discussions, that demonstrate your understanding of the subject matter and your adherence to the assignment requirements.
3. **Comparative Analysis:** Compare your work to the grading criteria and any exemplary solutions or model answers that were provided. Highlight areas where you believe your work meets or exceeds the expectations outlined in the course.
4. **Addressing Feedback:** If you received feedback from the initial grading, explain how you have incorporated that feedback into your work and why you believe it should lead to a higher grade.
5. **Clarity in Communication:** Ensure your appeal is well-organized, concise, and respectful in tone. Clearly articulate your points and avoid unnecessary emotional language.
6. **Meeting Deadlines:** Check the institution's policies regarding grade appeals and deadlines. Make sure your appeal is submitted within the specified timeframe.

Other Important Information

Academic Calendar and Important Dates

<https://www.ubalt.edu/academics/classes-and-registration/academic-calendar.cfm>

Recording Statement

Course Zoom recordings can be accessed through Panopto on Canvas.

Faculty may be required to record classes for the purposes of accommodating a disability or may opt to do so for students who cannot attend or who wish to review the full class content. All recordings are for the sole use of class instruction and study and may not be reproduced by students for any other purpose; to do so is a conduct violation. Faculty cannot reproduce students' voices or images from the class for any other purpose without additional student consent. All such recordings are protected by a UB login process based on where they are posted. Students may mute their microphone or turn off their camera if they do not consent to be recorded, but this may mean they need to find additional ways to participate in class. Faculty are to notify students when a class is recorded.

Students can use a virtual background on Zoom to protect their privacy while remaining clearly in attendance and engaged in class. Students should keep in mind that faculty have to be able to determine if a student is truly participating in a class to comply with University and federal attendance policies. A student could be deemed absent if logged in to a synchronous class but not responding. Visual and/or audio presence may be required for examinations or other types of assessment.